staged narrative photography

Elliot Krasnopoler, PhD

today's plan

- history painting and the tableau

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- history painting and the tableau
- what is staged narrative photography

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- history painting and the tableau
- what is staged narrative photography
- why artists turned to it?

today's plan

- history painting and the tableau
- what is staged narrative photography
- why artists turned to it?
- examples, influences, and practices

section i.

history painting and the tableau

Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin
Portrait of Joseph Aved
1734

Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin
The Draftsman
1737

Carrie Schneider

Women reading Women series

2012–14

Jeff Wall
Adrian Walker, artist, drawing from a specimen in a laboratory in the Dept. of Anatomy at the University of British Columbia, Vancouver
1992

Jean-Baptiste-Siméon Chardin
The Draftsman
1737

Jeff Wall
Adrian Walker, artist, drawing from a specimen in a laboratory in the Dept. of Anatomy at the University of British Columbia, Vancouver
1992

Jean-Baptiste Greuze
The Village Bride
1761

Jacques-Louis David
Oath of the Horatii
1784

key points

- absorption denies the existence of a beholder
- tableau paintings use this strategically to tell stories entirely within the frame
- this innovation shapes both the history of painting and eventually the history of photography

section ii.

what is staged narrative photography

Julia Margaret Cameron
King Lear Alotting His Kingdom to His Three Daughters
1872

Julia Margaret Cameron
Vivien and Merlin
1874

Henry Peach Robinson
Fading Away
1858

some notes on terms

still life
Roger Fenton, c. 1860

advertising
Kodak, 1944

Walker Evans
Corner of Kitchen and *Farmer's Kitchen*
1936

Cindy Sherman
Untitled Film Still #21
1978

staged narrative often has
a relationship to history

Jeff Wall
After "Invisible Man" by Ralph Ellison, the Prologue
1999–2000

Stan Douglas
Club Versailles, 1974
2012

a word on technology

Gregory Crewdson
Untitled, Winter (Bed of Roses)
2005

further notes on terms (and what isn’t “tableau”)

Alec Soth
Charles, Vasa, Minnesota
2002

Greg Miller
National Date Festival
2007

Hannah Starkey
Untitled, May
1997

Deana Lawson
Mama Goma, Gemena, DR Congo
2014

key points

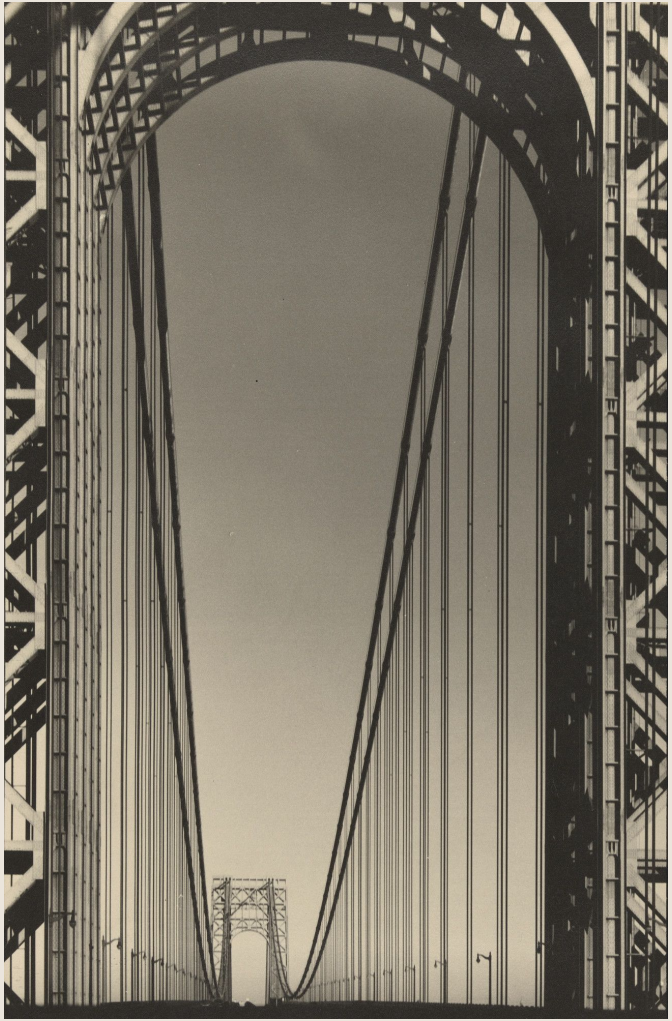
- photographs have been staged since the medium was invented
- but “staged narrative photography” that emerged in the 1970s has several specific characteristics that unite it

section iii.

why artists turn to staged photography?

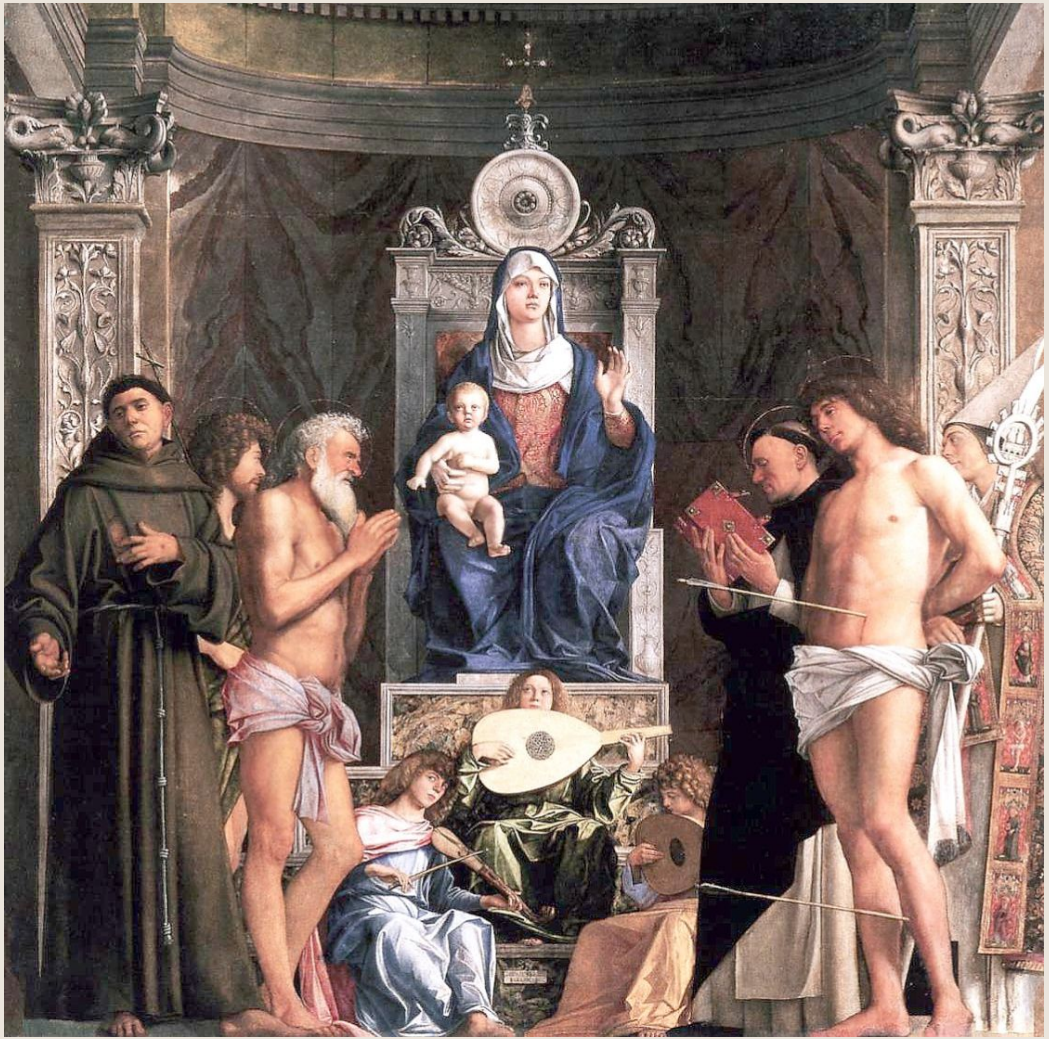
modernism/postmodernism

Edward Weston
Dunes, Oceano
1936



Margaret Bourke-White
George Washington Bridge
1933

Adi Nes
Job and Friends
2007



Giovanni Bellini
San Giobbe Altarpiece
c. 1485

Adi Nes
Job and Friends
2007

Jeff Wall
A Sudden Gust of Wind
1993

Hokusai
Yejiri Station, Province of Suruga
c. 1832

Jeff Wall
A Sudden Gust of Wind
1993

truth and fiction

Kelli Connell
Sweetwater, in *Double Life*
2002–present

Kelli Connell
This Morning, in *Double Life*
2002–present

Kelli Connell
Carnival, in
Double Life
2002–present

Philip-Lorca diCorcia
New York
1993

Philip-Lorca diCorcia
Tokyo
1998

Jeff Wall
Men Waiting
2006

mass-media saturation

Cindy Sherman
Untitled #476
2008

Alex Prager
California, too
2024

Andreas Gursky
99 Cent
1999

key points

- even as they rely on photography and technology, these works are subversive of the medium itself
- they examine the medium and its methods of making meaning (post-modernism and post-structuralism)
- they mix, borrow, and overlap among cinema, painting, and photography, and visual culture broadly

section iv.

examples, influences, and practices

staged photography and the history of art

Jeff Wall
Adrian Walker
1992

Jeff Wall
A Sudden Gust of Wind
1993

Yinka Shonibare
The sleep of reason produces monsters (Australia)
2008

les songes
de la raison
produisent-ils
des monstres
en Australie?

El sueño
de la razon
produce
monstruos

Yinka Shonibare
Diary of a Victorian Dandy: 14:00 Hours
1998

William Hogarth
A Rake's Progress
1733

Yinka Shonibare
Diary of a Victorian Dandy: 14:00 Hours
1998

Stan Douglas
Abbott & Cordova, 7 August 1971
2008

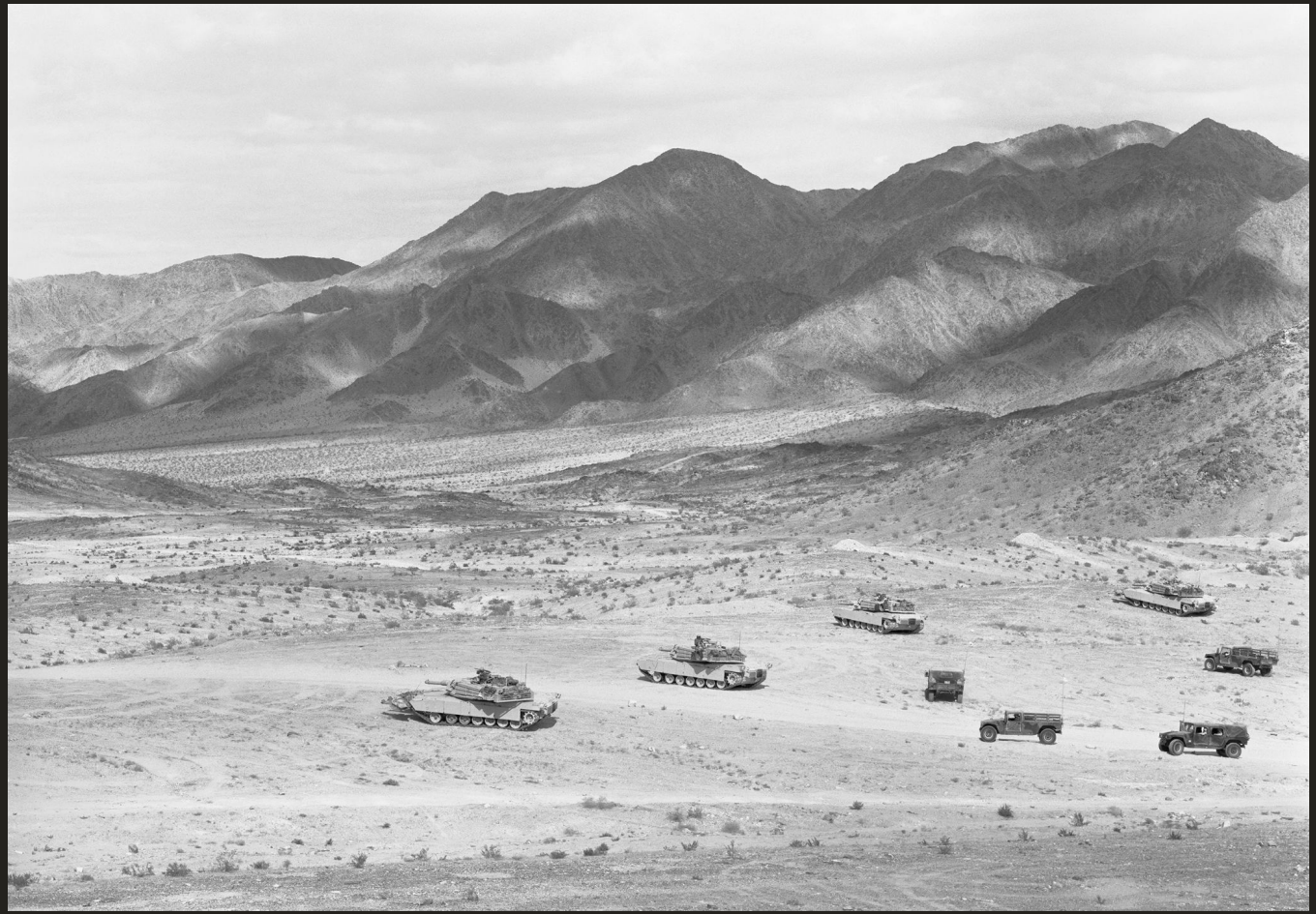
the documentary tradition

Philip-Lorca diCorcia
New York
1993

Hannah Starkey
Untitled, January 2013
2013

Hannah Starkey
Untitled, November 2007
2007

An-My Lê
Rescue, from the series *Small Wars*
1999-2002



An-My Lê
Mechanised Assault,
from *29 Palms*
2003-2004

Deana Lawson
Ring Bearer
2016

Deana Lawson
Mama Goma, Gemena, DR Congo
2014

family

Sally Mann
Gorjus
1989

Larry Sultan
My Mother Posing
1984

Larry Sultan
Empty Pool
1991

Tina Barney
Sunday New York Times
1982

…and cinema

Cindy Sherman
Untitled Film Still #21
1978

Gregory Crewdson
Untitled, Winter (Bed of Roses)
2005

Gregory Crewdson
Untitled (Ophelia)
1998-2001

Alex Prager
La Grande Sortie
Lower Level, Door 2
2016

Alex Prager
Play the Wind
Welcome Home
2019

Carrie Mae Weems
Untitled (Woman and Daughter with Children), from
The Kitchen Table Series
1990

Carrie Mae Weems
Untitled (Man Smoking/ Malcolm X), from
The Kitchen Table Series
1990

key points

- this is only a selection of topics, and there is overlap between topics
- this medium was both responsive and pioneering
- the staged narrative was an expansion of how photographs could operate as works of art
- photography during this period entered the world of “Art” with a renewed vigor